Conditional types 2 and 3

Objective: Form and use conditional type 2 (unreal present) and type 3 (unreal past) correctly to talk about imaginary situations and their results.

In two lines: Type 2 imagines a situation that is not true now or is unlikely in the future. Type 3 imagines a different past that can no longer be changed.

Type 2 (unreal present)	Type 3 (unreal past)
If + past simple would + base verb	If + past perfect would have + past participle
If I had time, I would help. (I don't have time now)	If I had had time, I would have helped. (I didn't have time then)

Figure 1: The structure of type 2 and type 3 conditionals, with the real meaning behind each one.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Type 2:** If + past simple, would + base form. It describes an unreal or unlikely situation in the present or future.
2. In type 2, we often use **were** for all persons in formal English: *If I were you, I would apologise.* (used for advice)
3. **Type 3:** If + past perfect, would have + past participle. It describes an imaginary past and its imaginary result.
4. **Modals:** *could / might* can replace *would*: *If he had trained, he might have won.*
5. **Clause order:** the if-clause can come first (followed by a comma) or second (no comma).
6. **Never** put *would* in the if-clause.

🟢 Examples

1. Complete: If people (help) each other more, the world (be) a better place.
   Answer: helped / would be. **Explanation:** unreal present, so type 2.

2. Combine: She didn't join the charity club. She didn't meet new friends. **Answer:** If she had joined the charity club, she would have met new friends. **Explanation:** both facts are past, so type 3 with opposite (positive) meaning.
3. Rewrite: I am not rich, so I can't help the poor. **Answer:** If I were rich, I could help the poor.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Writing *If I would have known…* instead of *If I had known…*
- Mixing tenses by mistake: *If he had studied, he would pass* when the meaning is completely past (use *would have passed*).
- Forgetting to reverse the meaning: negative facts become positive in the conditional, and vice versa.
- Using the past simple instead of the past participle: *would have went* instead of *would have gone*.

🟡 Quick review

- Type 2: If + past, would + verb (unreal now).
- Type 3: If + had + V3, would have + V3 (unreal past).
- If I were you… = giving advice.
- No *would* after *if*.
- Reverse the meaning of the original facts.

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